INITIAL DESIGN PROPOSAL

1636 N. College Avenue, Fort Collins, CO
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Summary

The proposed redevelopment of 1636 North College Avenue seeks to transform a vacant, car-oriented commercial parcel into a mixed-use, pedestrian-oriented community hub that supports sustainability, equity, and cultural identity within North Fort Collins. The site, formerly home to an Albertsons grocery store, currently consists of expansive asphalt parking areas, deteriorating infrastructure, and underlying environmental contamination. The proposal addresses these challenges by introducing human-scale design, green infrastructure, and community-oriented spaces that respond directly to the needs and aspirations of the surrounding neighborhood.

The design vision reflects an ongoing effort to serve the majority Hispanic community in this area, where organizations such as La Familia provide cultural, social, and educational support. Through inclusive engagement and careful consideration of historic underinvestment, the proposal repositions this site as a civic anchor - a focal point for recreation, culture, and small-scale commerce that enhances quality of life while preserving neighborhood character.

Concept and Framework

Concept Title: The Green & Cultural Gateway

The concept for 1636 N. College envisions a transitional node between Downtown Fort Collins and the northern suburban corridor, a gateway connecting ecological systems, social networks, and cultural identity. The design functions as a point of convergence where mobility, public space, and community gathering overlap, creating an accessible, vibrant, and inclusive environment.

Core Design Principles

- Human-Scale Redevelopment
  Replace oversized parking surfaces with woonerf-style corridors, shaded pedestrian pathways, and protected bike facilities. Prioritize comfort and safety for those walking or cycling.
- Cultural Identity and Inclusion
  Incorporate bilingual signage, local art installations, and flexible gathering spaces inspired by community-led precedents such as El Centro de la Raza and Absalon Folkehuset.

- Environmental Remediation and Green Integration
  Apply phytoremediation planting (Poplar trees, Tall Fescue) and bioswale systems to address soil and stormwater contamination, while improving site ecology and resilience.
- Compact Mixed-Use Development
  Redevelop existing structures to support a blend of housing, retail, and community functions, modeled after successful adaptive reuse precedents such as Belmar and Krog Street Market.
- Community-Centered Public Realm
  Establish a central civic plaza and recreation hub that hosts local events, markets, and cultural programming to strengthen neighborhood cohesion.

Design Response to Existing Conditions

Social and Cultural Context

Demographic data identifies the North College neighborhood as a predominantly Hispanic, lower-income community, with a median age of 26 and a poverty rate exceeding 28%. Recognizing the area's legacy of disinvestment, the proposal emphasizes representation, affordability, and inclusivity. Partnerships with La Familia and local leaders will guide public art, design features, and programming to ensure community ownership of the space.

Urban Form and Circulation

Existing infrastructure supports vehicular movement but offers limited safe options for pedestrians and cyclists. The design introduces:

- Pedestrian-priority corridors with retractable bollards for flexible access.
- Protected bicycle lanes along Blue Spruce and Bristlecone Drives.
- Enhanced pedestrian crossings and potential grade-separated connections to improve safety and continuity.

These interventions reduce auto dominance while reinforcing connections to surrounding housing and planned transit improvements, including the North College Bus Rapid Transit corridor.

Environmental and Sustainability Measures

The site’s history of petroleum contamination and its large impervious surfaces pose environmental challenges. The design mitigates these through:

- Remediation planting zones utilizing native and adaptive species.
- Green roofs for stormwater retention and urban cooling.
- Permeable paving systems to reduce runoff and mitigate heat island effects.

- Solar-integrated rooftops and passive shading strategies for energy efficiency.

These elements collectively advance citywide sustainability goals while enhancing ecological performance at the site level.

Economic and Equity Considerations

Located within an Urban Renewal Area and Tax Increment Financing District, the site is positioned for catalytic reinvestment. Redevelopment will leverage these incentives to provide mixed-income housing, community services, and small business opportunities. Aligning with ongoing affordable housing initiatives along North College, the proposal ensures redevelopment benefits existing residents and supports anti-displacement objectives.

Alignment with Community and Sustainability Goals

- Active and Low-Carbon Mobility
  Woonerfs, protected bike lanes, and transit-priority corridors encourage mode shift.
- Equitable Access to Amenities
  Central recreation hub, bilingual wayfinding, and flexible gathering spaces.
- Environmental Remediation
  Phytoremediation plantings and bioswale integration improve soil and water quality.
- Cultural Continuity
  Public art, cultural programming, and local vendor support reinforce neighborhood identity.
- Economic Vitality
  Mixed-use infill and small-scale retail promote local entrepreneurship.
- Climate and Social Resilience
  Green infrastructure, renewable integration, and adaptable public spaces prepare for long-term change.

Summary Statement

The redevelopment of 1636 North College Avenue is envisioned as a comprehensive reinvestment in the physical, social, and environmental health of North Fort Collins. Through a framework grounded in sustainability, cultural inclusion, and equitable design, this project transforms an underutilized commercial parcel into a vibrant, community-serving destination. One that bridges historical divides and fosters a resilient urban future for the North College corridor.